

Dreadful *her.*

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CHAPTER 2:

THE Revelation

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***“As I Said (he gritted his teeth),
Deal would be done on its time,
NOW GET THE FU** OUT OF HERE”***

– The glass hit the wall and chunks of smashed glass flew that made them quicken their paces. In a blink of an eye, the room was empty as all the men rushed out ...the last one closed the door with shaking hands.

His breath wasn't normal by the sudden rage ... first time in his years of Age, someone has turned him down... and who? A mere 19-year-old girl?



The scene from yesterday came across his mind once again spreading the redness of insult all over him.

He put his smartphone out , typing in someone's chat

HIM : *Prey isn't what we expected, the deal is pretty hard this time.*

He closed the chat and put it down sitting on a large sofa in a stiff posture. And unexpectedly the phone chimed within seconds,

MAN : *I don't need your excuses , make it work anyhow*

HIM : *Can we hunt for something else?*

MAN : *not a chance !*

MAN : *I didn't expect this from you, have some dignity.*

This made him even more anxious and he stood up frantically calling him

“what did you bark!” he shouted!

“either you make it work, (stretched silence) or be ready for the consequences”

“you can’t touch a strand of mine” he laughed with disgust visible, mocking the person on the phone, but he knew he didn't stand a chance against him or them.

“Right! I can’t But they can and you have better idea ... Who they!” – again the same irritating calmness

He ended the call with such a monstrous way abusing the person.

The raged heat started enveloping him even if the air conditioner was on its full speed. In one swift motion he tugged his shirt aside, the anger rigidity could be seen all over his body ... the stretched muscles and the blue nerves in arms and neck were making the chaotic edge obvious where he was standing ... on his death bed, with a shovel in hand to dig his own grave.

The tap rewinds the events of last 15 days and stops at 16th May 2021

16th May 2021

The bell was ringing when she came out of her room in dizziness, she hadn't fully awakened yet when the bell rang again.

“Sarah Bii” – she called her out with a visible irritating tone, the only woman overtaking these minor tasks.

The middle aged woman appeared from the staircase coming down from the rooftop,

“what are you even doing, the bell is ringing for like half an hour” – she said irritatingly curling in the large sofa with sleepy eyes ..

“I was making sure the new girl is working fine washing cloths , let me see ” –

Huriya didn't bother to answer and closed her eyes slowly lying against the back. The bell rang again. Soon she arrived back with a bucket of pink tulips in white packing with a card on it, almost hidden behind the tulips petals, Huriya slowly opened her eyes and scowled,

“What is this”

“A man gave it saying, it's ... for you ma'am” she handed it over to Huriya that made her eyes open wide leaving no trace of dizziness or sleep there.

“Wh ..what?” – she wasn’t sure what she heard getting those for Sarah’s hands. And embarrassed hurried towards the room with it.

No sooner had she returned and locked the door when she started racing his mind , not with any emotions but suspicion ... She took a picture of it and sent it to the girls group without even noticing the card hidden behind the pink tulips.

- *Who did that?*

No response ...

- *I didn’t know now we are starting the trend of sending each other’s anonymous flowers [laughing emoji]*

Still No response

She checked the ‘message info’ instantly and no one has seen it yet.

Her slight grin started to faint as her sight got the hidden card, her fingers moved to part the tulips away that were hiding the words.

“A Reminder... Soon, you won’t have to belong anywhere else...

And I do keep my promises!

– this is just a thanks to the lemonade.”

This was enough for her to throw the flowers away that fell on her bed, a natural instinct that made the hair on the nape of her neck stand straight, parting her mouth in astonishment.

“what a ... ” – she couldn’t say a word on this man’s audacity who has entered her life obviously out of nowhere.

Her gaze lingered upon the bucket on the opposite edge of bed, besides the softness, serenity of flowers, it was giving the most burdened feeling in this very room making her area of breathing smaller because even if she wasn’t self-involved in any fling, this *thing* right there could cause any possible suspicion ... ruining her entire personality.

(“Oh No No”) - She started pacing ... *(“Okay first , RElax!”)* her inner voice tried to calm her down and she obeyed.

(“1 , 2 , 3”)- she inhaled with her hands moving along, like forcing the air inside her lungs with closed eyes.

(“Goood , Now 1, 2, 3”) - she breathed out slowly moving her hands in same direction slowly opening her eyes, and it really helped her calm down slowing the machinery of her mind.

(“Did he really take me like one of those girls , Huh! (an unbelievable sigh escaped her) ”) - her mind started thinking now.

“he is sooooo gonna regret” she said out loud enough to hear her words clearly.

Outside a black Cadillac Escalade was standing in the shade of a big Oak Tree, he was sitting inside , the cool breeze coming out of the car air conditioner and black mirrors being a barrier between the interior and outside sunlight-dripping-street was making quite a contrast in the weather.

Wearing a chocolate coloured shirt that was showcasing his muscles, he was deep in thoughts , which ones? No one could guess as he was an Open Book in an Ancient language he invented himself.

No sooner had the phone rang when he received the call ...

“Initiated The progress?”

“Yes ” he said as his gaze flickered upon the Maroon Gate on the opposite side of the street.

“Good”

“Look ... ” he said upon the realization that the other person is going to hang up now.

“We were aiming for little girls as far as I remember.” His voice was deep, low but void of any humanity as always when he is taking his work seriously.

“I don’t doubt your remembrance” the same calm voice but void of any relaxation, firm, inflexible.

“Our target is a teenager, well we assumed but she is quite young. Like a Woman. We never made a deal over a woman ... all our previous deals were like 8-10 years but she signi..”

“I don’t fing care, she is THE target.”*** The caller’s voice did get higher, stopping him mid-sentence by grinding his teeth.

“We are on a mission, we do what we are told - NO ARGUMENTS - Remember that”
And the line cut with these final words.

He has played the very game multiple times before. Working with an anonymous team, he hasn’t seen any of them nor they did .. but one thing for sure, when the deal is made — a bag full of cash, fifty percent, is always found inside his apartment, sometimes in the outside balcony like someone has thrown inside or in the lawn. The rest is delivered when the deal is closed fulfilling its purpose.

Multiple girls, getting along with him on events, on public sessions or any place, he played the dirtier than other anonymous members.

First locking the target (the target is always decided by the person who asked him to join the team), getting along with the target, making them feel comfortable and then ... deliver them in a box in an unconscious state to the multiple delivery addresses he has received and saved in his notepad for years.

Each year, New target , New Dealer , New cash commitment, ranging from 10-20 million , New delivery address .. mostly near ports

And all of this started when he was struggling under the debt his father left on his own death, a death of mere 50k that felt like forever to pay off, he remembered leaving college to work on a 9-5 shift in a call center - UK-based local company earning 20k per month, managing rent, bills and debt savings.

He clearly remembered the day he made a call and was caught up as a fake person irrespective of his excellent British Accent , and then the person offered him his personal number

He looked on his left, people busy in working , calling , typing, keyboard clicking, mouse movement, responding , chantings , echoed voices, the same on his right and then he looked down and gradually hold the pen to right down the number that changed his life and made him ... an inhumane thing... a monster.

One who doesn't own a heart anymore ... But in no time ... he cleared the debt ... his small rented residence in a small local area changed to a well built society, her 70cc bike replaced by Civic first, then BMW, then Cadillac Escalade - his dream car
His mother who lived in a village with his father's relatives started getting money ... not 2k , but real money, more and more ,... to have her buy a house , gave a lot of prayers to him and eventually dying unaware of the darkness that has befallen her only son.

His life flashed upon his eyes as his gaze was still fixed on the Maroon Gate of that House, standing with its Might in the sunlight dimmed by the mirrors of his Cadillac Escalade.

He couldn't recall the faces of the girls he had boxed up and delivered but he couldn't forget the first one, very first ... a 7 year old girl , fragile, with the cutest smile and sparkling eyes ... Meerab.

Mahir's jaw tightened as the flashback hit him like a storm that made his chest tighter. He started the car engine and drifted off to another route with mind mingling the present and the past.

Years ago

It was a huge ship, a great one, standing with all its might in the ocean. Mahir, in the last year of his teens, could see the vastness from the bank he was standing on in an ordinary chequered shirt. Lights were all over the great sculpture standing right in front of him, his lens dilated in awe, slightly his lips parted, "Wow", a sighed appreciation .. for the very thing he has only seen on TVs and couldn't assume it actually exists.

He stepped towards the entrance when he saw two men wearing black tuxedos stepping into his way,

"Your Pass! Please" - the slightly younger one said

"Umm I ... i was called by .. "

"NO entries are allowed without a pass. " - the middle-aged one spoke with brutality written all over his face.

"By?" the other one spoke out with patience.

"He didn't tell his name , he ... said to tell you ... 'the oceans and the 7 skies.. are in a' .. umm!"

He swallowed hard. The little sweat drops appeared on his head when he found himself forgetting the line he had repeated till getting lost in the wonderness of this grand ship.

"Mystery of Nobody who created fragiles to be the preys."

The younger one completed the sentence.

"Yeah yes, ... this is ...it" he noticed both of them exchanging glances and with a final firm determined eyes, they parted, giving enough space for him to climb up the entrance of that grand miracle.

"Take two rights and then down stairs and then straight until you reach the room 201"

And with a heavy sigh he finally entered.

People ... a lot of people, rich ones, well-dressed irrespective of the local area he belongs to. Women, Liberal, well-dressed but void of their religion copying the western culture in every way possible.

Men holding wine glasses, what they were actually drinking, he had no idea. The whole plot was seeming to be a dramatic thing his senses could never perceived, and as he turned two rights and stepped down , he found himself in a quiet hallway ... rooms were aligned on his left and right , few had their doors open, others were locked.

He could hear the voices of women, laughing ... men mumbling, ... he did hear voice of children from one of the rooms but couldn't figure out the words or the weight of their conversations.

Room 199 , he stepped forward.

Room 200 (opened with a few men inside , as one of them sensed someone outside .. he reached the door and closed it with a thud on his face.)

Room 201.. Locked

He took a deep breath and slightly knocked on the door — No response for 3 minutes This made his nerves rushing to get the blood from his heart as he felt the absence of oxygen.

He then knocked again, harsher this time. And then the door swung open.

“Umm Yes!?” A woman opened the door, her face clearly giving the expression that she wasn't expecting any guests.

she wasn't younger nor middle-aged or maybe her maintenance was hiding her age. Her hair was sleek and her face was lightened up with makeup highlighting every detail, she was dressed in a modest way, still no sign of any scarf but her dressing wasn't showcasing her body making her somewhat different than the other women he has seen his way here.

“I, ... I..” his words didn't come out as it wasn't the person he was assuming to attend him.

“Who's it Esha?” A middle-aged man appeared from behind , for one moment looked at him standing outside their room with narrowed questioning eyes then quickly replaced by a slight smile and a knowing look.

“Oh You must be Amaan right?” for one second he couldn't speak on hearing the wrong name. And then the man's voice recalled in his mind that he had a conversation a while ago and got the address of this ship.

“Whatever they say, agree with it”

“Umm yes, I'm ”, he again swallowed something as his adam apple moved, giving an obvious nervous look on his face.

“Oh You're sweating, come inside!” - they both moved to let him enter.

The inside area was a well-furnished room with a much cooler environment, he shuddered for a moment when the cool air conditioned breezes touched the sweating parts on his back.

“Please get comfortable and sorry for making you wait” - the man smiled again leading him to a comfortable sofa. The woman moved to an attached smaller room.. He assumed it to be an attached kitchenette .

He looked around, everything was quite antique and well-placed, as the ship was standing on the water, it was slightly moving with the waves.. Even those were enough to have their part in his nervousness.

He could sense there were more than one living thing in that small kitchenette.

And then he saw the woman coming out with fresh kiwi beautifully cut in halves decorated with lemons and mint leaves aside and placed them on the table in front of them. Behind her followed smaller steps with crackling glasses as their sides were touching with each step taken ahead, as she moved, he could see the fragile hands taking steady steps towards the table.

“Ah, My little princess!” - the man beside him placed his hand on his chest exclaiming. And her lips parted in a heartfelt grin. One tooth was missing from the left side while the others were bright white and straight. Her eyes were amber colored, holding slightly larger lenses than average humans, little dots of spark were visible as she grinned. She placed the glasses' tray beside the kiwi's that holds fresh pomegranate juice.

The sight crept a slight smile on Mahir's face.

After placing she held her one hand by the other behind her back looking down smiling and waving on her toes with the joy she was carrying.

“Say hello to Brother, he is your birthday event planner this year” - the man slightly pulled her by one arm to his lap and she shyly nudged her face to his chest that made the viewers laugh decently. The woman had already taken her place in the cornered sofa.

Besides the coziness, thoughts started gathering, what if he is in the wrong room? What if the real Amaan appears? I should tell them I am not ...

“Your organizer asked us to make a call with you when you reach here... take it” - the man handed him over a phone which he took hesitatingly.

“So you reached there and ... for this deal, you are Amaan, understand!?”

“Yes .. sir!” he said as he looked towards the man talking with her little girl that was still shy in his presence.

“You are an event planner and he hired you from an organization.. We will share the documented details to your address soon ..., we are faking everything ... but act along it. Make the deal .. plan the event or not ... its your choice! ... We... need the girl!”

“Whatt ??” the sudden burst of question let everyone looked at him, the woman who was using her phone first looked at him and then her husband .. the man was calm but his eyes

aroused questions in them and the girl, she looked at his face for the first time fully with dilated eyes.

The phone call was cut.

“What happened?” - the man asked when Mahir stood up.

“Something urgent came up, they asked me to come earlier ... umm .. my .. my mother is very ill” - a straight lie but he couldn't stand another second here.

“Oh , let me drop you at yo-” the man quickly stood up when was cut mid-sentence

“No, I'll manage.” and with those final words and a last look at the girl standing behind her father grabbing his trousers' sides - looking at him with that magnificent innocent gaze pursuing the unknowing-face, he turned and with a few strides left the room leaving all of them speechless.

He didn't look back or give any attention to the surroundings and rushed to the exit. The same door from where he entered a while ago making his way out parting away the guards that were still there.

The younger one made a call as he walked pass by in a rush.

“He just left the ship.” and he held the phone near his ear as he was informing the person while his gaze was fixed on the teenager who left ... as if he could just leave now... as if.

As he reached home, and locked the door of his small residence, the door get knocked in a fierce way. He clearly remembered how he digitally signed the contract earlier this day and put his thumb print to ensure he has joined them for the great deal of money he hadn't even seen yet and the document did say that the only way to be out is death.

He grabbed the steel pipe and took steps towards the door, steady, cautious and measured, with visible fear of death on his face and as he unlocked it, there was the owner of the house standing, the old hag.

“Where were you.. brat!” - she said as she stepped inside without an invitation. Mahir instantly moved his hand laced with steel pipe behind his back which fell off.

“I, i was .. ”

“Whatever, grab this, your mother sent” - she handed him over a suitcase with a small digital lock over that. The appearance was telling, it wasn't from his mother.

He took that while there was still fear locked in places and his hands were showing signs of little trembling, but the woman was still looking at the bag, her fixed gaze as if she's trying to tear that suitcase down and see for what's inside by his gazing power.

“Okay, i got this” he said awkwardly gesturing towards her time to leave.

“Whom do you think YOU ARE TALKING LIKE THATT” - her features shifted to rage in one single moment that made him step back.

“PAY your fare by tomorrow or PACK YOUT SHIT OUTTA HERE... ridiculous” she said in such a shrieking voice that made him force shut his eyes and the woman left closing the door with a thud that made a much louder noise awakening the sleepy birds in nearby trees.

He quickly locked the door before coming inside, a message had dropped to his phone a while ago, maybe half an hour ago when he left that ship.

“08320”

No subject line, no description, just a fiver letter code which he clicked on digital lock and the suitcase unlocked with a click. As he opened it ... there were five-thousand-rupee notes, how many? He couldn't guess as he shut it down instantly looking around to confirm if someone had witnessed that or not.

He slowly opened it again with a racing heart, beside the decently placed currency notes, there were a file .. as he opened the file.

SUBJECT ID : 08320
RESOURCE : *Amaan Azhar (made-up name)*
CHARACTER: *Event Planner*
TARGET : *Meerab Hussain*
TARGET VISUALS :

[image: it was an HD camera shot taken from afar. The little girl was playing on a sea saw and was laughing as her hair was flowing. Her dad was standing behind her holding the sea saw end. It was day light image.]

TARGET DETAILS :

Meerab is a 7 year old girl. His father Hussain owns a shipping company in chicago (continuous para with further details)

TIMELINE: *End of November*
DELIVERY ADDRESS: *[anonymously written there]*
STATUS OF TARGET : *Alive*

NOTE : Any attempt to involve police or any other person will make you next on target list with STATUS = Dead. The amount you are seeing is you advance, fifty

percent that is a total of five million, rest five million would be made clear when the target is delivered on the address.

He closed the file and looked at the cash, five million? For the moment no thought of his own death occurred to him but the amount that was written... five million?

He couldn't believe what was happening, yesterday he was calling his folks for ten thousand to pay the rent and today ... he had five millions?

He looked at the girl in the image, laughing with her head slightly falling back, flowing hair as her father stood near. Then he looked at decently placed five-thousand-rupee notes, multiple ones.

He again looked at the girl photo and then the money.

The blurred moment far somewhere in his brain when he wished to be millionaire in nursery and everyone laughed because his father was a farmer who died in his very farm, his mother was on the mercy of his uncles' in that small village, his whole life he planned how to earn more than twenty thousands and now ... five million were placed right there, under his palm, like a miracle.

Tears slipped from his eye corners, one , two , two together.

These were enough to bury every humiliation he had swallowed. Enough to erase the nights he had slept hungry. His fingers tightened around the edge of the suitcase.

By the time the suitcase closed... he wiped off the last tears of his life, the last sign that showed he had a soul, the last spirituality he ever hold.

And in a month, he planned the event ... called the best decorators in the whole city. The whole park was broadcasting something, world has never seen. After she cut the cake and everyone cheered and later started talking, eating, he approached her and she hugged him.

She has become so fond of him in a month, her parents sighted the event and continued their conversations with other rich personalities they called out. A thing of riches to show off.

He sat down on his knees,

"You want your gift?", she nodded with all her might.

"Don't tell baba hmm?, it's a huge gift" - he said with void expressions, his voice did not sound real.

She nodded again, grinning ... ***"w..what .. ?"***

“You saw the van in which I came with your cake?” - she again moved her face instantly, grinning up and down.

“Go there... I’m coming” he slightly brushed his thumb on her soft pink cheeks. His own eyes were empty, not signaling any sign of humanity within him. He wasn’t even forcing a smile. He was dead inside.

*And with a wide smile and sparkling eyes,
she ran, ..*

Ran towards her grave ...

towards the end of her joy that started the very day...

she ran grinning, with stumbling steps ...

towards the darkness of this world no one ever told her about!

See you in the next chapter